Designed for the In-Between

Alexander Clarke

Arianna Nunez

Cecilia Bilski

OPPORTUNITY

Project framing

Students want to stay active in clubs and campus life, but time conflicts and workload spikes make that balance feel stressful and unsustainable.

Research signal
Burnout builds near exams and deadlines

Core tension
Belonging vs. responsibility

Design direction
Make planning feel lighter and earlier

Personas synthesized from interviews + affinity clustering

Olive

The Overloaded Achiever

2nd-year engineering student focused on grades and staying competitive.

Goals
- High GPA
- Meet expectations

Pain points
- Perfectionist
- Burnout over time

"If I don't give 100%, I feel behind."

Support should step in before perfectionism becomes burnout.

Ella

The Exhausted Multitasker

Engineering student active in clubs who wants both experience and a social life.

Goals
- Stay active
- Build experience

Pain points
- Little downtime
- Overwhelmed

"There just aren't enough hours in the day."

Planning must reduce guilt, not just organize time.

Dylan

The Disconnected & Overwhelmed Student

Motivated student who becomes mentally drained as deadlines pile up.

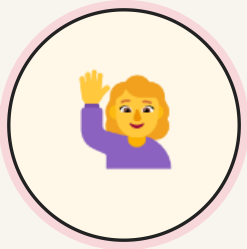
Goals
- Keep up
- Regain motivation

Pain points
- Fatigue
- Unclear support

"I know the school has resources, but I don't know where to start."

Support must feel obvious and low-effort.

Chosen persona: Ella - The Exhausted Multitasker



Engineering student involved in clubs and activities. Ella wants to build experience, stay social, and still finish big assignments on time.

Context of use

Busy weekdays, stacked coursework, club events, and finals pressure

Goals

Stay active, build her resume, and keep decent academic performance

Pain points

Not enough hours, low downtime, sleep sacrifice, overwhelm

Representative quote
“There just aren’t enough hours in the day.”

Key insight

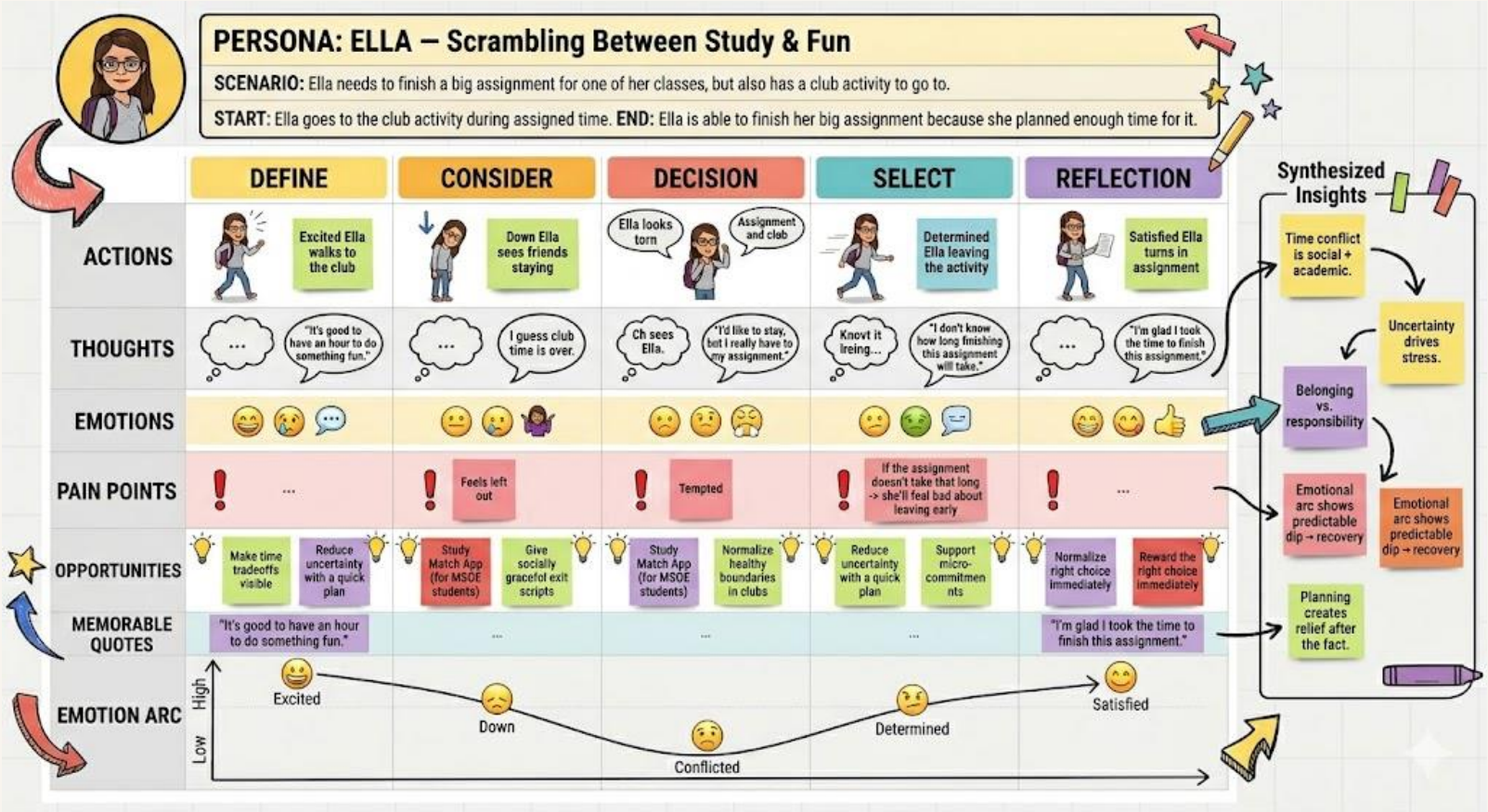
Ella does not need motivation to care. She needs a calmer way to see tradeoffs, protect study time, and leave activities without feeling like she is letting people down.

This persona anchors the journey map and prototype flow.

Current-state journey map

The emotional arc shows a predictable dip around the decision point and relief only after planning a workable next step.

Scenario: Ella needs to finish a major assignment, but she also has a club activity she wants to attend.



SYNTHESIS

Insights and opportunity areas

Time conflict is emotional	Students are not just scheduling tasks - they are navigating guilt, belonging, and academic pressure.
Stress spikes are predictable	Workload pile-ups around exams and deadlines create crisis moments that could be planned for earlier.
Support must feel low effort	If help feels like “extra work,” burned-out students will postpone it.
Academic + social planning should live together	Students need one place to see classes, study blocks, and clubs together.

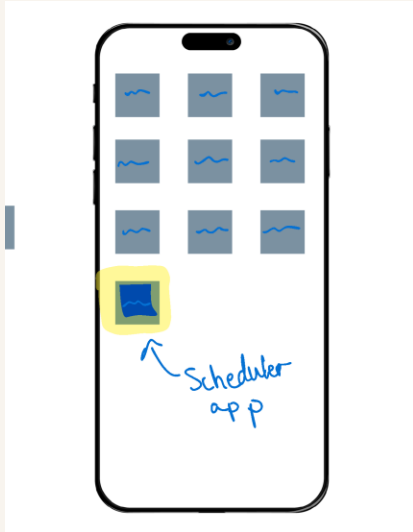
How Might We...?

- help students anticipate pile-up weeks and plan earlier so deadlines do not become crisis moments?
- reduce the social pressure to stay longer when students need to prioritize academics?
- make stress-support resources feel easy, normal, and not like extra work?

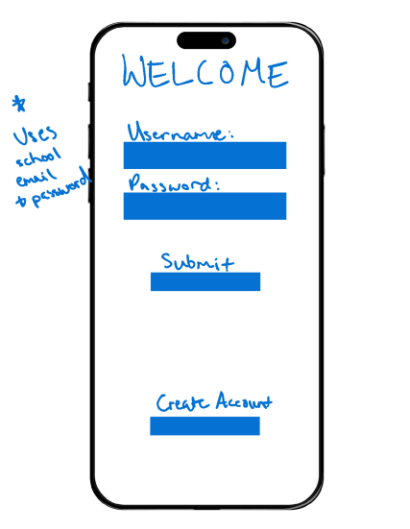
HMW help students stay accountable to planned study time without sacrificing clubs and social connection?

Prototype direction: final low-fidelity screens

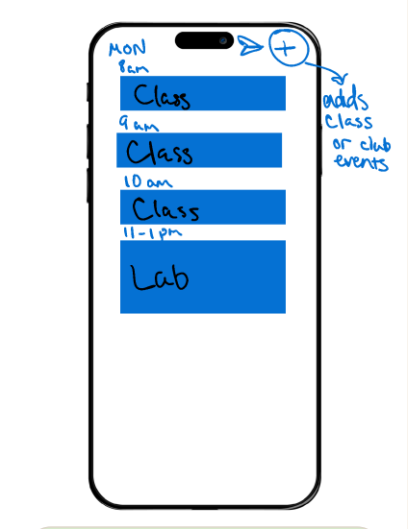
After sketching multiple concepts, the team translated the strongest path into a clearer phone-based flow.



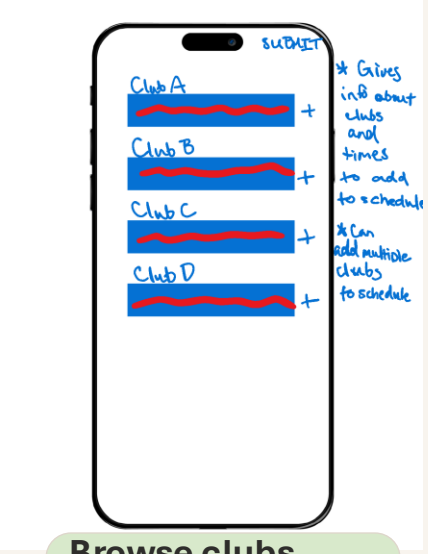
Entry point
Launch the scheduling app.



Welcome / sign in
Start with school email and account setup.



View schedule
See classes first, then add events.



Browse clubs
Review club options and choose what to add.

Why this concept

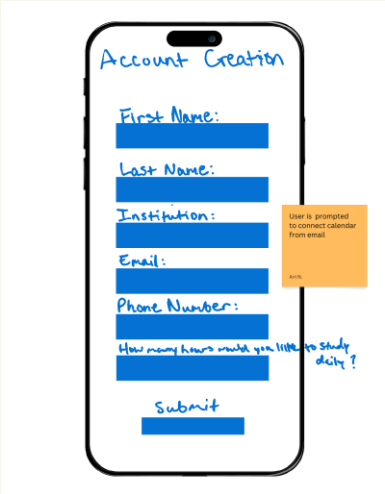
- Keeps academic and social planning in one place
- Makes schedule tradeoffs visible before stress spikes
- Adds study time proactively instead of waiting for a crisis
- Leaves room for a social layer through sharing with friends

Chosen concept: final low-fidelity prototype flow

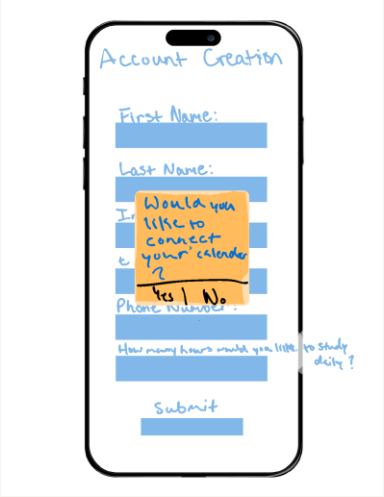
**********Recommended walkthrough scenario: Ella creates an account, connects her calendar, adds clubs, accepts the recommendation, and sees study time placed before the activity. The flow then lets her share the plan with friends.******

What the user does
Creates a profile, chooses clubs, and reviews a suggested plan.

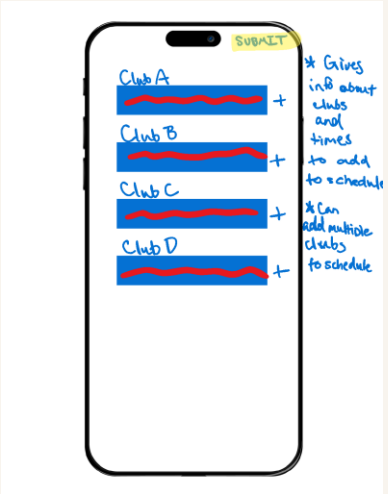
What the system does
Uses the calendar to place a study block before the chosen activity.



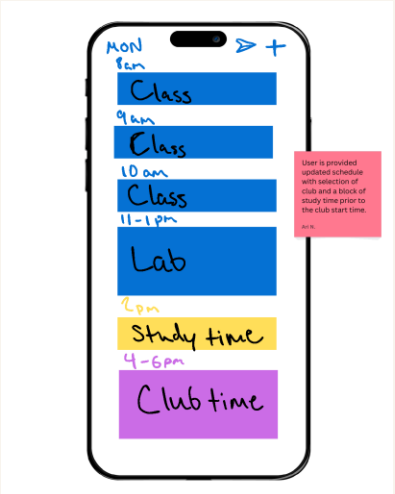
1. Account setup
Enter school info and daily study preference.



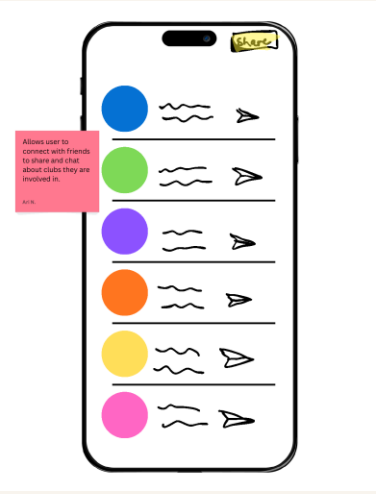
2. Connect calendar
Sync class schedule during onboarding.



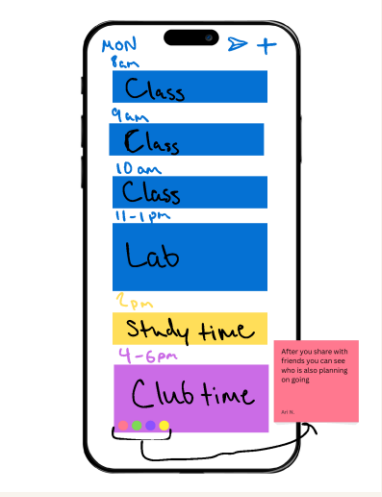
3. Add clubs
Select one or more organizations to join.



4. Updated plan
Study time is placed before club time.



5. Share with friends
Open the social layer to compare plans.



6. See who is going
Friends appear directly on the event block.

Reflection + next steps

What we learned

- Students want help before they feel overwhelmed.
- Planning has to reduce guilt, not just optimize time.
- Low-fi testing worked best when the flow stayed simple and easy to narrate.

What worked in testing

- The process was straightforward and easy to follow.
- Participants could understand the scenario with minimal prompting.
- The concept felt relevant to real MSOE routines.

Next steps toward high fidelity

- Allow rescheduling of study blocks
- Add longer-term planning views
- Increase prototype realism and interaction depth
- Refine resource visibility and sharing features

This phase sets up the next prototype round by clarifying who we are designing for, where the stress peaks, and which interactions need to feel most supportive.

Appendix / submission assets

1. Personas document
UXD1001_Team4_UserPersonas.pdf

2. Study protocol
Team 4 Study Protocol.pdf

3. Insight prompts / HMWs
Warm-Up-Insight recall.pdf

4. Final low-fi prototype
Lofi-Prototype_iPhone (1).pdf

Final checklist

- If needed, add interview notes in the appendix

.